

ENTRY LEVEL SOLUTIONS

The Junior League

With their low power requirements and good video decoding capabilities, these cards make excellent companions for all home PCs

Minnows are generally found in larger quantities than bigger fish, but this time round we could only scrape up four of them. This is due in part to the tremendous drop in prices of mid-range cards in particular. With prices of mid-range cards crashing through the four-thousand-rupee barrier, it seems there's nowhere for the entry level cards to go...the whole "between a rock and a hard place" analogy comes to mind.

The entry-level category was all NVIDIA, and only two chipsets—the new GF 8400GS and the older GF 7300GT.

An Affordable Foursome

The lowest bracket consisted of two cards from Sparkle. One was an 8400GS-based card, and the other a 7300GT-based solution. The other two DX 10 parts were from BIG and Galaxy; both these are 8400GS solutions.

None of these cards come bundled with any games; this is not a surprise, really, considering the prices. We were surprised, though, to see good connector bundles with each card—just as was the case in the mid-range category. This, we say, is a welcome trend.

At the very outset, we wish to make one point crystal clear: these cards aren't for gamers—and you'd be doing a grave injustice to any game released over the past two years by



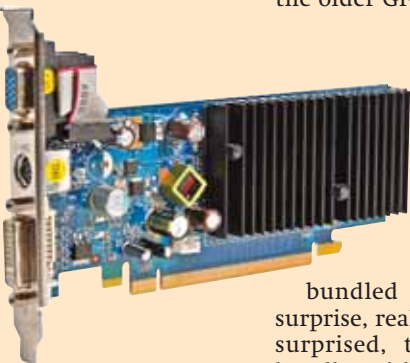
Sparkle PCX 7300GT
Not good value any more



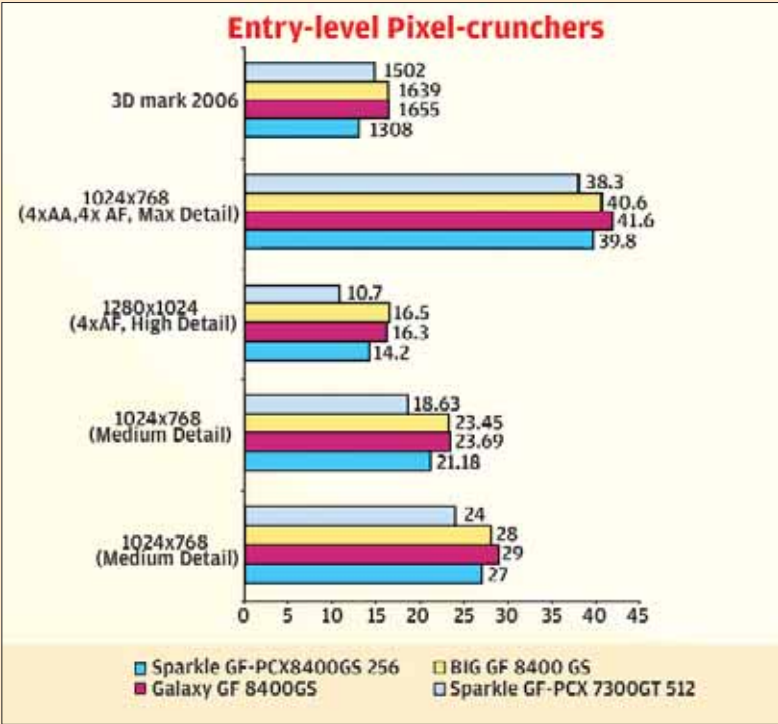
BIG 8400 GS
The biggest minnow!



Galaxy 8400GS-256MB
Good for HTPC users



Sparkle PCX 8400GS 256MB
A seriously affordable solution



buying one of these cards to play it! Such entry-level chipsets have one catch-phrase—HTPC. With their smaller form factors, low power requirements and good video decoding capabilities (excellent for the 8400GS chipset) these cards make excellent companions for all home PCs. And yes, you'll be able to play the odd game too, at lower resolutions and settings!

Sparkle's 7300GT offers 512 MB of video RAM—as mentioned earlier, this doesn't really add to performance in any way. Moreover, the 7300GT isn't DX 10 compatible, and is overpriced—especially considering the similar performing 8400GS chipset-based cards.

If you're looking for something really cheap to build an HTPC, or even a good multimedia PC, we recommend you give onboard graphics a skip and pick up a Sparkle GF PCX 8400GS 256—a real steal of a deal at Rs 2,600. For just Rs 300 more, you could get a Galaxy GF 8400GS—a slightly better performer mainly due to marginally higher core and memory clock speeds. ☑